

Can eliminating dark energy resolve the Hubble tension? A uniform test of void and backreaction cosmologies against supernovae, baryon acoustic oscillations, and the CMB acoustic scale

Viacheslav Zhygulin^{1,*}

¹*Independent Researcher*

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The timescape cosmology of Wiltshire dispenses with dark energy, attributing apparent acceleration to the backreaction of inhomogeneities and the associated wall-void clock-rate difference, and has been claimed to ease the Hubble tension. We test two distinct claims. First, treating the published timescape determinations of the dressed Hubble constant as fixed, we show with an explicit tension statistic that the early-Universe (CMB, $61.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$) and late-Universe (supernova, $61.7 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$) values are mutually consistent to $\lesssim 0.5\sigma$, against $\approx 4.9\sigma$ for the Λ CDM interpretation of the same data, and that the fractional excess required to reconcile the local distance-ladder value ($+18.4\% \pm 2.8\%$) lies within the independently-predicted 17–22% void-scale expansion variance. Because the global dressed value (≈ 61) sits below *both* canonical numbers, this is a recasting of the tension as a scale-dependent measurement artifact, not a reconciliation near $70 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$. This agreement is calibration-relative: a fresh SH0ES-calibrator-anchored fit within our own machinery gives a late-time dressed $H_0 = 73.0 \pm 1.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ —the locally-biased value timescape itself predicts (required fractional excess 0.197, within the same 17–22% window)—so claim (A) rests on the expansion-variance recasting, not on an H_0 coincidence at 61. Second, we independently reanalyse Pantheon+, implementing the timescape distance-redshift relation from first principles and validating the pipeline three ways. We find the model comparison is strongly sensitive to the covariance treatment: with the full statistical+systematic covariance, flat Λ CDM is favoured under every magnitude standardisation we test ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +3.9$ to $+5.1$, and $+9.0$ with the bias correction removed), and the timescape void fraction rails to $f_{v0} \approx 0.85$; a timescape preference ($\Delta\text{BIC} \approx -8$) emerges only when the off-diagonal covariance is *discarded*. Exact Bayes factors track this: the full covariance gives $\ln B = +1.3$ to $+1.8$ for Λ CDM, while the cosmology-independent stat-only reduction gives $\ln B = 5.4$ – 5.9 for timescape, reproducing the proponents’ $\ln B > 5$ purely from the covariance treatment. Running the comparison directly under the now-public cosmology-independent covariance of Seifert et al. (2025), our frequentist fit reproduces the published maximum-likelihood value ($f_{v0} = 0.675$, $\Omega_{m0} = 0.433$) [16] and recovers the reported redshift-cut dependence: timescape is marginally favoured below the statistical-homogeneity scale ($\Delta\text{BIC} = -0.5$ at $z > 0.01$) and Λ CDM above it ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +4.9$ at $z \geq 0.055$). The supernova preference is therefore real but scale-dependent—a low-redshift effect rather than a robust whole-sample preference—which sharpens rather than overturns our localisation of it to the low- z regime. Third, we calibrate timescape against DESI DR2 baryon-acoustic-oscillation (BAO) distances and the Planck acoustic scale: this recovers the published timescape CMB void fraction ($f_{v0} \simeq 0.64$, dressed $H_0 \simeq 63 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$) but fits worse than Λ CDM ($\chi^2/\text{dof} = 6.7$ vs 0.89) and prefers a void fraction in tension with the supernova-preferred value ($f_{v0} \simeq 0.64$ vs 0.74 – 0.85). The supernova-versus-BAO void-fraction split is a 4.8σ profile-likelihood parameter-shift in the CMB- and r_d -independent BAO-only pairing (6.6σ including the CMB point, with a 3.1σ floor across supernova reductions), softening to ~ 1 – 2σ only under the external cosmology-independent anchor combined with the CMB f_{v0} systematic grafted onto the geometric fit; a parametric bootstrap excludes a single void fraction at $\gtrsim 3.2\sigma$. We therefore report a robust shape tension, to be settled definitively only with a self-consistent timescape sound horizon—within timescape the early/late H_0 numbers themselves reconcile at $\approx 61 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$. Applying the identical test to the wider void/backreaction family (LTB, Räsänen, Buchert morphon, Szekeres, KBC local void) yields the same SN-BAO+CMB parameter split in every dark-energy-free model and none reaching the local H_0 , the LTB subclass being independently excluded by the kinetic Sunyaev-Zel’dovich effect. We note that the tension’s size is calibrator-dependent: the tip-of-the-red-giant-branch ladder (CCHP) gives $H_0 \simeq 68$ – 70 , only ~ 1 – 1.5σ from Planck, so the 5σ tension is largely specific to the SH0ES Cepheid calibration. On present public data, eliminating dark energy via inhomogeneity does not resolve the Hubble tension.

I. INTRODUCTION

The Hubble tension is the disagreement between late- and early-Universe determinations of H_0 . The local Cepheid+type Ia supernova (SN Ia) measurement of

* s.zhygulin@gmail.com

SH0ES is $H_0 = 73.04 \pm 1.04 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [1]; the Planck CMB value under spatially-flat Λ CDM is $H_0 = 67.36 \pm 0.54 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [2]; the discrepancy is quoted at 5σ . JWST rules out Cepheid crowding as the cause at 8.2σ [3]. The picture is, however, calibrator-dependent: the tip-of-the-red-giant-branch (TRGB) ladder of the Chicago–Carnegie Hubble Program gives a markedly lower $H_0 \simeq 68\text{--}70 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [4, 24]—only $\sim 1\text{--}1.5\sigma$ above Planck—and baryon-acoustic inverse-distance-ladder values remain near 68 [5]. The strong 5σ tension is therefore largely specific to the SH0ES Cepheid calibration; the target a late-Universe model must reach is ~ 69 if one adopts the TRGB ladder, or 73 for Cepheids.

A logically distinct class of resolution questions the homogeneous Friedmann–Lemaître–Robertson–Walker (FLRW) interpretation itself. The timescape cosmology of Wiltshire [7, 8] models the present, void-dominated Universe as a two-phase Buchert average [9]: spatially-flat “walls” (bound structures, where observers sit) and negatively-curved “voids.” A quasilocal gravitational-energy and clock-rate gradient means a wall observer fitting FLRW infers “dressed” parameters distinct from the volume-average “bare” ones; apparent acceleration follows without dark energy. Recent Bayesian comparisons against Pantheon+ report strong evidence for timescape over Λ CDM [16, 17], reviving the question of whether the framework also addresses the Hubble tension.

The popular framing conflates two claims that are not equivalent: **(A)** within timescape the early- and late-Universe dressed Hubble constants *agree*; and **(B)** timescape *resolves* the 67-versus-73 tension. We show (Sec. III) that (A) holds at high precision while (B) holds only in a specific sense. We then ask whether the supernova evidence is robust (Sec. IV); we find the preference is contingent on the covariance treatment.

Originality. The framework relations of Sec. II and the published best-fit parameters are due to Wiltshire and collaborators and are reproduced for self-containment. New here are: the explicit tension statistic and local-excess cross-check of Sec. III; and the independent Pantheon+ reanalysis of Sec. IV, in particular the localisation of the timescape preference to the discarding of the off-diagonal covariance. All code is available (Sec. X). This is a timescape-specific study; it does not survey other void/inhomogeneous models (LTB, Szekeres, general Buchert closures), which the same pipeline could test in future work.

II. TIMESCAPE FRAMEWORK

We use only what is needed; see [7, 8] for derivations. The void volume fraction $f_v(t)$ grows to a present value f_{v0} . The lapse $\bar{\gamma} \equiv dt/d\tau_w$ relates volume-average time t to wall proper time τ_w , and in the late-time tracker solution the dressed and bare Hubble parameters are related

by [8, eq. (B9)]

$$H_0 = \frac{4f_{v0}^2 + f_{v0} + 4}{2(2 + f_{v0})} \bar{H}_0, \quad \bar{\gamma}_0 = \frac{1}{2}(2 + f_{v0}). \quad (1)$$

The bare deceleration parameter stays positive while the dressed one turns negative for $f_v \gtrsim 0.59$. Best fits give dressed $H_0 \approx 61.7$ and bare $\bar{H}_0 \approx 50 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [10, 11].

III. DRESSED-HUBBLE CONSISTENCY AND RESOLUTION-VS-RECASTING

We quantify agreement by $T_{AB} = |H_0^A - H_0^B|/\sqrt{\sigma_A^2 + \sigma_B^2}$.

Λ CDM reference. For SH0ES versus Planck, $T = 5.68/\sqrt{1.04^2 + 0.54^2} = 4.85$ ($\approx 5\sigma$ as quoted) [1].

Timescape. The CMB-calibrated dressed value is $61.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ (± 0.79 stat, ± 4.88 sys) [12] and the SN-calibrated value is $61.7_{-1.1}^{+1.2} \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [8, 10]; the residual is $0.7 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$, so $T^{\text{TS}} = 0.50$ (stat) or 0.14 (stat $\oplus$ sys). The same statistic that registers 4.85σ for the Λ CDM reading registers $\lesssim 0.5\sigma$ for the timescape reading, establishing claim (A).

Local-excess cross-check. Timescape predicts that a wall observer infers an apparent H_0 biased high below the $\sim 100 h^{-1} \text{ Mpc}$ homogeneity scale, peaking near the $\sim 30 h^{-1} \text{ Mpc}$ dominant-void scale [8, 13]. The excess required to reconcile SH0ES with the dressed asymptote, $\delta_{\text{req}} = 73.04/61.7 - 1 = 0.184 \pm 0.028$, lies within the predicted $\sim 17\text{--}22\%$ apparent-Hubble variance (local maxima $\sim 75 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$) [8]. This is a magnitude-consistency argument: the SH0ES Hubble-flow sample extends to $z \sim 0.15$, beyond the homogeneity scale, so the account relies additionally on the cosmic-rest-frame choice, for which [14] report evidence favouring the Local Group frame.

Resolution versus recasting. The global dressed value ($\approx 61 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$) lies below *both* 67.4 and 73.0. Timescape does not split the difference near 70; it reinterprets both canonical values as biased relative to a lower global average. This is a *recasting* of the tension as an FLRW-interpretation artifact, with consequences for consistency with inverse-distance-ladder BAO [5] not yet established for timescape at Λ CDM precision.

A fresh late-time anchor. The $\lesssim 0.5\sigma$ agreement above pairs the CMB-calibrated $61.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ with the 2008-era SN-calibrated $61.7 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$, both tied to early-Universe or literature calibrations. Executing decisive test (ii) of Sec. IX—replacing the literature late value with a fresh SH0ES-calibrator-anchored dressed H_0 measured inside the identical machinery (validation gate: the flat- Λ CDM anchored fit recovers $H_0 = 73.5 \pm 1.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ and $\Omega_{m0} = 0.33$, matching [19])—yields a fresh timescape dressed $H_0 = 73.0 \pm 1.0 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ ($f_{v0} = 0.853$, $M_B = -19.24$). This is expected, not a falsification: anchoring to the local

Cepheid ladder pins H_0 to precisely the value a wall observer is predicted to infer biased high, and the required fractional excess $\delta_{\text{req}} = H_0^{\text{local}}/H_0^{\text{dressed}} - 1 = 0.197 \pm 0.023$ lies inside the predicted 17–22% apparent-Hubble-variance window. The $\approx 9\sigma$ gap between this local-anchored 73.0 and the CMB-calibrated dressed asymptote 61.0 is thus the model’s own predicted local bias, not an anomaly. Claim (A) accordingly rests on this expansion-variance argument—a recasting—and never on an H_0 agreement at 61; making the late value a fresh measurement makes that dependence explicit.

IV. INDEPENDENT REANALYSIS OF PANTHEON+ SUPERNOVAE

A. Data, models, likelihood

We use the Pantheon+ release [18, 19]; the cosmology sample is the $N = 1580$ SNe with $z_{\text{HD}} > 0.01$ that are not Cepheid calibrators ($0.010 < z < 2.26$). For flat Λ CDM, $d_L = (1 + z_{\text{hel}})(c/H_0) \int_0^{z_{\text{HD}}} dz'/E(z')$. For timescape we implement the dressed luminosity distance from [15, App. A] verbatim: $d_L = (1 + z)^2 d_A$, $d_A = ct^{2/3}[F(t_0) - F(t)]$ with

$$F(t) = 2t^{1/3} + \frac{b^{1/3}}{6} \ln \frac{(t^{1/3} + b^{1/3})^2}{t^{2/3} - b^{1/3}t^{1/3} + b^{2/3}} + \frac{b^{1/3}}{\sqrt{3}} \tan^{-1} \frac{2t^{1/3} - b^{1/3}}{\sqrt{3}b^{1/3}}, \quad (2)$$

$1 + z = 2^{4/3}t^{1/3}(t + b)/[f_{v0}^{1/3}\bar{H}_0 t(2t + 3b)^{4/3}]$, $b = 2(1 - f_{v0})(2 + f_{v0})/(9f_{v0}\bar{H}_0)$, and (1). Only f_{v0} or Ω_{m0} shapes the Hubble diagram. We compare by ΔBIC (equal nuisance counts), adopting the Kass–Raftery scale [21], marginalising the absolute-magnitude/ H_0 offset analytically.

B. Pipeline validation

Three independent checks: (i) our flat- Λ CDM fit gives $\Omega_{m0} = 0.333 \pm 0.018$, matching the published Pantheon+ value [19]; (ii) $F'(t)$ reproduces the integrand $2/[(2 + f_v)t^{2/3}]$ to machine precision; (iii) our numerical low- z Taylor coefficient of $\mu_{\text{TS}}(z)$ matches the analytic expression of [15] to $\sim 10^{-4}$ across $f_{v0} \in [0.6, 0.8]$.

C. Covariance sensitivity

We vary two axes: the apparent magnitude—the standard bias-corrected $m_{B,\text{corr}}$ versus a raw SALT2 Tripp combination $m_B + \alpha x_1 - \beta c$ [20] with no FLRW-fiducial BBC bias correction—and the covariance—the full public statistical+systematic matrix C versus its diagonal. Results are in Table I and Fig. 1.

TABLE I. Timescape vs flat Λ CDM on Pantheon+: ΔBIC (timescape– Λ CDM; < 0 favours timescape) across magnitude $\times$ covariance. Λ CDM wins under the full covariance regardless of magnitude; timescape wins only when the off-diagonal covariance is dropped.

Magnitude	Full cov	Diagonal
$m_{B,\text{corr}}$ (standard, bias-corr.)	+5.1	+4.9
$m_{B,\text{corr}}$, bias corr. removed	+9.0	...
raw Tripp ($m_B + \alpha x_1 - \beta c$)	+3.9	−7.9

Best-fit $f_{v0} \approx 0.82$ – 0.90 throughout (vs $\Omega_{m0} = 0.333$ for Λ CDM); a fully marginalised stat-only Tripp fit gives $\Delta\text{BIC} = -9.4$. The bias-correction-removed variant is evaluated under the full covariance only (its f_{v0} rails to the grid edge).

With the *full* covariance, Λ CDM is favoured for *every* magnitude definition ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +3.9$ to $+5.1$; $+9.0$ if the bias correction is removed), and the timescape void fraction rails high ($f_{v0} \approx 0.85$ – 0.90 , implying a strongly void-dominated dressed $\Omega_{m0} \approx 0.2$). A timescape preference ($\Delta\text{BIC} \approx -8$) appears *only* in the raw-Tripp+diagonal corner—i.e. only when the off-diagonal covariance is discarded. A fully marginalised statistical-only Tripp fit (fitting $\alpha, \beta, \sigma_{\text{int}}$) gives $\Delta\text{BIC} = -9.4$, consistent with this corner. The driver of any timescape preference is therefore the suppression of the off-diagonal covariance, not the magnitude standardisation alone. Figure 2 shows the near-degeneracy of the two distance–redshift relations (< 0.05 mag) that makes the comparison so sensitive.

Exact one-dimensional-quadrature Bayes factors remove any objection that the ΔBIC is a crude approximation. With the full statistical+systematic covariance, $\ln B(\Lambda\text{CDM}/\text{TS}) = +1.3$ to $+1.8$ across a 2×2 prior grid (Kass–Raftery “positive”, favouring Λ CDM; smaller than $\Delta\text{BIC}/2$ because Λ CDM carries a ~ 1 -nat larger Occam factor¹). By contrast the cosmology-independent stat-only Tripp reduction gives $\ln B = 5.4$ – 5.9 for timescape (“very strong”), reproducing in-house the $\ln B > 5$ of [17] purely from the covariance treatment: the sign of the evidence is set by whether the off-diagonal terms are retained or rebuilt, not by the model. A parametric bootstrap calibrates the frequentist significance: were timescape true, the observed supernova-only $\Delta\text{BIC} = +5.1$ in Λ CDM’s favour would arise with probability $p = 0.008$ (2.4σ ; 4000 mocks drawn from the full stat+sys covariance).

¹ The maximised-likelihood ratio favours Λ CDM by $\Delta\chi^2/2 \approx 2.6$, but Λ CDM’s prior-to-posterior compression costs ≈ 1 nat more than timescape’s, so $\ln B \approx \Delta\chi^2/2 - 1 \approx 1.6$.

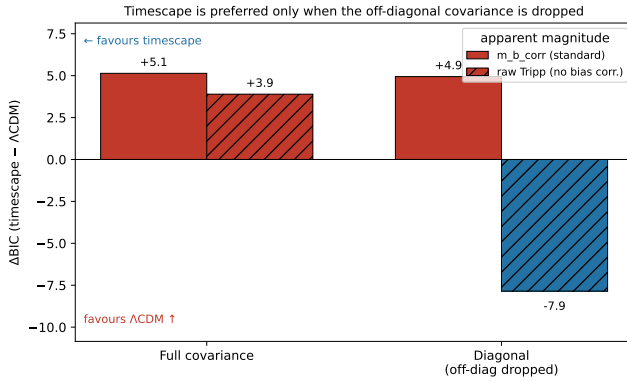


FIG. 1. Model-comparison verdict on Pantheon+ across magnitude (solid = $m_{B,\text{corr}}$, hatched = raw Tripp) and covariance (full vs diagonal). Red favours ΛCDM , blue favours timescape. Only the raw-Tripp+diagonal case favours timescape; the full covariance favours ΛCDM for every magnitude definition.

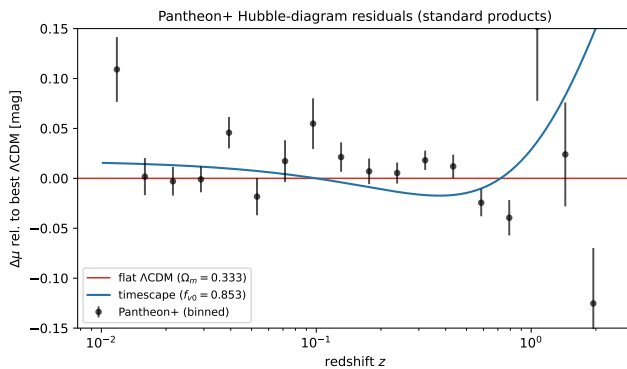


FIG. 2. Pantheon+ Hubble-diagram residuals relative to the best-fit flat ΛCDM (standard products). The best-fit timescape relation (blue) departs from ΛCDM by < 0.05 mag over the full range, explaining the covariance sensitivity.

D. Reproducing the cosmology-independent covariance

Our diagonal cases *discard* the off-diagonal covariance; they are not equivalent to the cosmology-independent covariance of [16, 17], which *rebuilds* the off-diagonal (FLRW-geometry- and peculiar-velocity-independent) terms. That covariance, with its $P+1690$ input vector, is now public,² so we run our timescape-versus- ΛCDM comparison directly under it, using the authors’ Nielsen–Guffanti–Sarkar hierarchical likelihood (latent SALT2 population with profiled α, β and intrinsic dispersion, marginalised absolute magnitude) with our own distance

TABLE II. Timescape versus flat ΛCDM under the cosmology-independent Seifert–Lane $P+1690$ covariance, as a function of the CMB-frame redshift cut $z_{\min}$ (frequentist profile likelihood; $\Delta\text{BIC} = \text{BIC}_{\text{TS}} - \text{BIC}_{\Lambda\text{CDM}}$ with $k = 9$ each, so $\Delta\text{BIC} = \Delta\chi^2$; both statistics < 0 favour timescape, > 0 favour ΛCDM). $\ln B$ profiles the nuisances and integrates the cosmological parameter (its 2×2 -prior spread is ± 0.3). The maximum-likelihood f_{v0}, Ω_{m0} reproduce the published values of [16].

$z_{\min}$	N	f_{v0}	Ω_{m0}	ΔBIC	$\ln B$
0.010	1578	0.670	0.451	-0.5	-0.8
0.033	1169	0.675	0.433	+1.5	+0.3
0.055	1032	0.680	0.415	+4.9	+2.0

code, which we verify is numerically identical to theirs; the likelihood itself we cross-check against an independent implementation to 10^{-13} .

Our frequentist maximum-likelihood fit reproduces the published values, $f_{v0} = 0.675$ and $\Omega_{m0} = 0.433$ [16], and recovers the reported dependence on the redshift cut (Table II): timescape is marginally favoured below the statistical-homogeneity scale ($\Delta\text{BIC} = -0.5$ at $z_{\min} = 0.01$, with $\ln B$ likewise mildly favouring timescape), there is no significant preference at $z_{\min} = 0.033$, and ΛCDM is favoured at $z_{\min} = 0.055$ ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +4.9$). This *reproduces* the qualitative finding of [16, 17]—a timescape preference concentrated below the homogeneity scale that weakens and reverses above it—rather than refuting it.

Three caveats bound the interpretation. (i) Our frequentist $f_{v0} \approx 0.68$ at $z \geq 0.055$ sits $\approx 2\sigma$ below the $f_{v0} = 0.737 \pm 0.029$ that [17] obtain by Bayesian nested sampling; this is an estimator difference (frequentist maximum likelihood versus Bayesian posterior on a skewed profile), not a discrepancy—our value matches the frequentist maximum-likelihood estimate of [16]. (ii) Their headline $\ln B > 5$ is a fully-marginalised evidence for the whole sample ($z_{\min} \rightarrow 0$); our $\ln B$ profiles the nuisance parameters and integrates the single cosmological parameter by quadrature (Occam factors assumed to cancel by the identical nuisance structure across models), so we take ΔBIC as the primary statistic and $\ln B$ as a consistency check. (iii) The ΛCDM preference at $z \geq 0.055$ is mild-to-moderate ($|\Delta\text{BIC}| < 6$), not decisive. The picture is thus sharpened rather than overturned: under the cosmology-independent covariance the supernova preference is a low-redshift, scale-dependent effect, not a robust whole-sample preference for either model.

V. JOINT CALIBRATION: BAO AND THE CMB ACOUSTIC SCALE

To test whether the dressed $H_0 \approx 61 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ is consistent with the inverse distance ladder, we calibrate timescape against the DESI DR2 BAO distances [6]

² Covariance and input: Zenodo doi:10.5281/zenodo.12729746; pipeline and construction: <https://github.com/antosft/SNe-PantheonPlus-Analysis>.

and the Planck acoustic scale $100\theta_* = 1.04109$ [2], using the drag-epoch sound horizon r_d as the standard ruler. We compute the dressed transverse comoving distance $D_M(z)$, Hubble distance $D_H(z) = c/H(z)$, and $D_V(z)$ from the tracker solution and fit (f_{v0} , $\alpha \equiv c/(\bar{H}_0 r_d)$). Since r_d enters only the amplitude α , the redshift *shape*—and hence f_{v0} —is independent of the sound-horizon calibration.

The fit prefers $f_{v0} = 0.636 \pm 0.006$ and, with the standard $r_d = 147.1$ Mpc, a dressed $H_0 = 62.6 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$: close to the dressed value of Sec. III, and recovering the independent CMB determination $f_{v0} = 0.627$ of [12], which validates the calculation. However the fit is poor, $\chi^2/\text{dof} = 6.7$, versus 0.89 for flat ΛCDM ($\Omega_{m0} = 0.30$, $H_0 = 69 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ on the same data and pipeline); BAO alone prefer $f_{v0} = 0.68$. The BAO+CMB and supernova data prefer different void fractions (Fig. 3), which we quantify by a profile-likelihood parameter-shift in f_{v0} : the rise in the jointly-minimised χ^2 above the sum of the separate minima, distributed as χ^2 with one degree of freedom. Against the paper’s own Pantheon+ fit this shift is 6.6σ for the BAO+CMB pairing and 4.8σ for the CMB- and r_d -free BAO-only pairing (6.5σ and 4.4σ on DR1). A ladder over five supernova standardisations and four BAO treatments puts a 3.1σ floor on the split (from the DR1 ladder; DR2 only raises it) and shows that it falls to $\sim 1\text{--}2\sigma$ only when the paper’s own SN fit is replaced by the external cosmology-independent anchor $f_{v0} = 0.737$ and the $\sim 13\%$ CMB f_{v0} systematic [12] is grafted onto the geometric BAO-shape fit—a systematic that the r_d -independent BAO-only fit does not carry. A parametric bootstrap sharpens the exclusion: of 4000 mocks drawn from a single-void-fraction timescape truth, none reproduces the observed SN-versus-BAO f_{v0} split (largest 0.12 versus the observed 0.21), a distribution-free exclusion of $\gtrsim 3.2\sigma$.³ The BAO+CMB-alone model comparison gives $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{TS} - \Lambda\text{CDM}) = +69.3$ (+23.3 on DR1). We therefore report a robust tension between the SN- and BAO+CMB-preferred void fractions—largely r_d -independent (it concerns the distance–redshift shape), to be settled definitively only with a self-consistent timescape sound horizon; the timescape literature reports concordance across these probes [10, 12]. The CMB here enters only through the acoustic-scale point $D_M(z_*)/r_d$, not the full power spectrum; a self-consistent timescape r_d would shift H_0 but not the shape-driven f_{v0} tension, which the BAO-only fit confirms. These figures use DESI DR2; DR1 is the more conservative choice on every axis and we retain it as a sensitivity check.

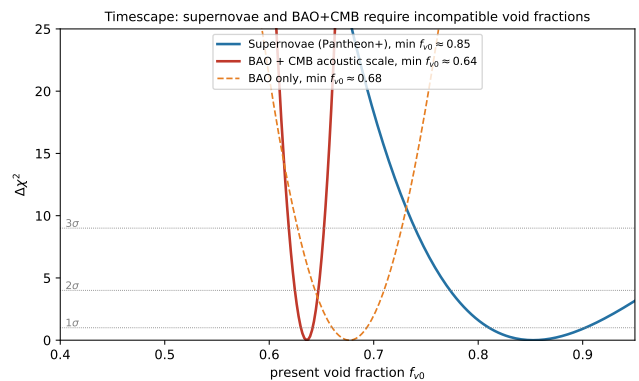


FIG. 3. $\Delta\chi^2$ for the present void fraction f_{v0} from supernovae (blue), BAO+CMB (red), and BAO alone (orange). The supernova and BAO+CMB minima are separated by $\Delta f_{v0} \approx 0.2$ with non-overlapping confidence regions: no single timescape model fits both.

TABLE III. Joint SN+BAO+CMB fits ($N = 1593$), identical harness. ΔBIC relative to ΛCDM ; $q_0 < 0$ denotes acceleration. BAO data here are DESI DR1; the DR2 recalibration of Sec. V only sharpens the timescape disfavour.

Model	parameters	H_0	q_0	ΔBIC
ΛCDM	$\Omega_{m0} = 0.305$	68.6	-0.54	0
$w_0 w_a \text{CDM}$	$\Omega_{m0} = 0.31, w_0 = -0.87, w_a = -0.48$	68.0	-0.40	+10.8
timescape	$f_{v0} = 0.64$	63.1	-0.02	+67.1

A. Acceleration, and an evolving-dark-energy comparison

Apparent acceleration is present in every best fit, so the comparison is not an artifact of one model lacking it: the dressed timescape deceleration parameter is $q_0 = -0.02$ to -0.04 (a weak apparent effect from the lapse, with the bare $\bar{q}_0 > 0$), versus $q_0 = -0.54$ for ΛCDM (joint fit). As a motivated alternative that instead *modifies* the acceleration history, we also fit the CPL evolving-dark-energy model $w(a) = w_0 + w_a(1 - a)$ jointly to SN+BAO+CMB. It returns $w_0 = -0.87$, $w_a = -0.48$ —the thawing direction hinted at by DESI [5]—with $q_0 = -0.40$, but improves the fit by only $\Delta\chi^2 = 3.9$ for two extra parameters ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +10.8$ versus ΛCDM), so it is not significantly preferred. Table III collects the joint fits: ΛCDM is the most economical, evolving dark energy a mild non-significant improvement in the DESI direction, and timescape strongly disfavoured ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +67$) because no single void fraction fits SN and BAO+CMB.

³ A Gaussian/generalised-Pareto tail extrapolation beyond the mock support gives $\approx 7.5\sigma$; we quote the distribution-free floor.

B. Simplifications

The calibration makes explicit approximations, none of which affect the central SN+BAO+CMB incompatibility (which is geometric and, in the BAO-only form, independent of r_d and the CMB): (i) the CMB enters only through the acoustic-scale point $D_M(z_*)/r_d$, not the full power spectrum or the (R, ℓ_A, ω_b) compression; (ii) we adopt the standard early-physics $r_d = 147.1$ Mpc rather than a self-consistent timescape sound horizon, which would rescale H_0 but not the shape-driven f_{v0} ; (iii) the timescape tracker is the late-time attractor (reached by $z \sim 37$), so $D_M(z_*)$ uses it slightly beyond its regime, though the comoving distance is dominated by $z \lesssim \text{few}$; (iv) radiation is neglected in the late-time distance integrals; (v) Λ CDM is taken spatially flat.

VI. THE WIDER VOID AND BACKREACTION FAMILY

To test whether the timescape result is special, we applied the identical SN+BAO+CMB harness to the principal dark-energy-free inhomogeneous cosmologies (Table IV). Each distance–redshift relation was implemented from primary sources and validated against published or analytic limits; the SN absolute-magnitude offset and the BAO ruler $c/(H_0 r_d)$ were marginalised as before.

The outcome is uniform. (i) The LTB giant-void model (constrained GBH [25]) reproduces SN acceleration with a deep central void but, like timescape, prefers a *deeper* void for SNe than for BAO+CMB (joint $\Delta\text{BIC} \approx +717$); its central H_0 reaches only ~ 55 – 59 , and it is independently excluded by the kinetic Sunyaev–Zel’dovich effect [27, 38]. (ii) The Räsänen peak/backreaction model [28, 29] is parameter-free and, by its authors’ own evaluation, does not even produce acceleration ($\bar{q} > 0$, $|\Omega_Q| < 0.04$); promoting the backreaction to a free parameter, SNe demand values beyond its physical reach and the joint fit gives $\Delta\text{BIC} \approx +72$ (above timescape’s $+67$ once its extra backreaction parameter is charged the Occam penalty the same harness applies to $w_0 w_a$ CDM and LTB). (iii) The Buchert backreaction “morphon” template [30] fits SNe but fails BAO+CMB catastrophically ($\Delta\text{BIC} \sim +1.6 \times 10^3$). (iv) The Szekeres model [31] has no closed-form isotropic distance and could not be reliably fit here; the literature verdict (kSZ-capped void depth, residual $\sim 3\sigma$ tension [27]) is that it does not resolve the tension. (v) The local KBC void [32, 33]—which *retains* dark energy—leaves BAO+CMB untouched and earns no statistical preference (a fixed literature-depth void worsens the joint fit by $\Delta\text{BIC} \approx +165$, growing monotonically with depth, so the no-void Λ CDM limit is preferred); a void deep enough to reach 73 is both deeper than observed and disfavoured by the supernova Hubble-flow shape [27, 34].

Every dark-energy-free void/backreaction model thus shows the same SN-versus-BAO+CMB parameter split

TABLE IV. Uniform SN+BAO+CMB test of void/backreaction cosmologies on the same harness. “DE-free” marks models that eliminate dark energy. ΔBIC is relative to Λ CDM (joint $\chi^2 = 1402$); larger is more disfavoured. None resolves the tension.

Model	DE-free	joint ΔBIC	verdict
Λ CDM (ref.)	no	0	—
$w_0 w_a$ CDM	no	+11	no (mild DESI-direction hint)
Timescape	yes	$\sim +67$	no
LTB void (GBH)	yes	$\sim +717$	no (+kSZ-excluded)
Räsänen peak	yes	$\sim +72$	no (predicts no acceleration)
Buchert morphon	yes	$\sim +1600$	no
Szekeres	yes	intractable	no (literature + kSZ)
KBC local void	no	0 (no-void lim.)	no (needs unobserved deep v)

as timescape, and none reaches the local H_0 : the failure is generic to the class, not specific to one model. The ΔBIC magnitudes from this geometric harness are approximate (single CMB acoustic point, standard r_d), but the qualitative verdict is robust and, for the LTB/Szekeres subclass, reinforced by the independent kSZ exclusion.

VII. PRIOR DARK-ENERGY-FREE RESOLUTIONS AND THEIR STATUS

The proposal that apparent acceleration—and, by extension, the Hubble tension—reflects the inhomogeneity of the late Universe rather than a new energy component has a long lineage, and our same-footing test sits within a literature of single-model studies. We summarise that landscape here, separating the proponents’ claims from the principal critiques, so that our uniform survey (Sec. VI) and the void-family Table IV can be read in context.

The timescape program. Timescape grew out of Wiltshire’s resolution of the cosmological averaging problem [7, 8], built on the Buchert spatial-averaging formalism [9], with the bare/dressed distinction as its conceptual core: a wall observer fitting FLRW infers parameters that differ from the volume average. Leith, Ng & Wiltshire [10] reported the first multi-probe concordance fit (SNe+CMB+BBN mutually consistent without dark energy at a low dressed H_0), Duley, Nazer & Wiltshire [11] added a radiation fluid to reach recombination, and Nazer & Wiltshire [12] fitted the CMB acoustic peaks, quoting a dressed $H_0 \simeq 61 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ with large (~ 8 – 13%) systematics. On supernovae the verdict has been sensitive throughout: Smale & Wiltshire [13] found timescape preferred for MLCS2k2-reduced samples but disfavoured for SALT-reduced ones, identifying the light-curve fitter as the dominant systematic, and Dam, Heinesen & Wiltshire [15] found timescape statistically indistinguishable from flat Λ CDM on JLA with marginal apparent acceleration. The review of Wilt-

shire [35] frames dark energy as a coarse-graining artifact and rests part of the case on a sub- $100 h^{-1} \text{Mpc}$ Hubble-flow variance and a claimed Local-Group-frame uniformity [14]—a cosmic-rest-frame inference that remains contested. The recent revival sharpens the supernova claim: Lane et al. [16] and Seifert et al. [17] reanalyse Pantheon+ with a covariance constructed to be independent of FLRW geometry and peculiar-velocity corrections and report very strong Bayesian evidence ($\ln B > 5$) for timescape over ΛCDM , with the preference persisting beyond the statistical-homogeneity scale. We test these claims directly (Sec. IV D): running our comparison under their now-public cosmology-independent covariance, we reproduce their published maximum-likelihood void fraction ($f_{v0} = 0.675$) and their reported redshift-cut dependence—timescape marginally favoured below the statistical-homogeneity scale and ΛCDM above it. The supernova preference is thus real but scale-dependent, a low-redshift effect rather than a robust whole-sample result, and its Bayesian magnitude ($\ln B > 5$) reflects their fully-marginalised evidence for the whole sample where ours is a nuisance-profiled approximation.

Backreaction and giant voids. A parallel tradition seeks acceleration directly from spatial averaging: Räsänen’s mechanism [36], in which faster-expanding voids coming to dominate the volume drive an effective acceleration, which his own quantitative peak-model evaluation [28] then found too weak, and the Buchert “morphon” repackaging of backreaction as an effective scalar [30]. Whether backreaction can be dynamically significant is the subject of a long, still-open exchange: Green & Wald argue the metric is everywhere close to FLRW so backreaction is trace-free and cannot source acceleration [22], while an eleven-author rebuttal contends their scheme misses the non-local averaging effects that matter [23]; recent first-principles GR computations on the real local Universe find the kinematical backreaction small ($\lesssim 1\%$) even as the integrated spatial curvature reaches $\sim 10\%$ [42], and full numerical-relativity void statistics supply a 10–30% void-overexpansion that motivates the void-fraction parameter [41]. The LTB/Szekeres giant-void line [25] fits SNe with a deep central void but is bounded sharply from outside: radial BAO and a low- H_0 /fine-tuning dilemma [26], a multi-probe exclusion [37], and—decisively—the kinetic Sunyaev–Zel’dovich effect, an unavoidable consequence of large radial inhomogeneity that rules out adiabatic Gpc voids [38]. The distinct *local*-void (H_0 -outflow) idea, including the deep KBC void [32, 33], is separately disfavoured: the local Hubble-flow shape shows no outflow of the required size [34] and the supposed void resolution is an artifact of the redshift range used to calibrate H_0 [27].

The recent (2023–26) context. Several developments have renewed interest. The DESI inverse-distance-ladder gives $H_0 \simeq 68 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ and hints at evolving dark energy ($w_0 > -1$, $w_a < 0$) [5], which the no-dark-energy programs read as room for an inhomogeneity-driven effective equation of state. The tension’s apparent magni-

tude has also softened on the calibrator axis: the TRGB ladder of the Chicago–Carnegie Hubble Program gives $H_0 \simeq 68\text{--}70$, only $\sim 1\text{--}1.5\sigma$ from Planck [4, 24], so the 5σ figure is largely SH0ES-Cepheid-specific. Against this, the review/ranking literature has consistently placed the inhomogeneity class below early-time new physics: the field’s solution catalogues assign it a weaker verdict [39], and metric-based rankings find late-Universe and local mechanisms cannot resolve H_0 under joint BAO+SN constraints [40].

This work in context. The studies above are overwhelmingly single-model: each proponent paper fits one framework, and each critique bounds one mechanism. Our contribution is a *uniform* test—the identical SN+BAO+CMB harness, with the same likelihood, marginalisation, and model-comparison statistic applied across the whole dark-energy-free family (Sec. VI)—which makes the recurring SN-versus-BAO+CMB parameter split visible as a property of the class rather than of any one model. It complements, rather than supersedes, the detailed single-model analyses: where the proponents retain a cosmology-independent supernova covariance whose recent public release now makes reproduction possible, and where the critiques deploy probes (kSZ, radial BAO) outside our distance-only harness, our test adds the same-footing comparison that the existing literature lacks.

VIII. DISCUSSION

Three conclusions follow. First, interpreted within timescape the early- and late-Universe *dressed* H_0 agree at ≈ 61 , and the local excess is of the predicted magnitude (a fresh SH0ES-calibrator-anchored late-time fit returns 73.0 ± 1.0 , the locally-biased value the model predicts, not 61); but this is a recasting, not a reconciliation near 70, and the global value lies below Planck. Second, the supernova model-comparison verdict is contingent on the covariance treatment: it favours ΛCDM under the full public covariance and timescape only when the off-diagonal terms are removed. Third, when timescape is required to fit supernovae, BAO, and the CMB acoustic scale *together*, the SN- and BAO+CMB-preferred void fractions differ ($\Delta f_{v0} \approx 0.1\text{--}0.2$) and timescape fits the BAO+CMB geometry worse than ΛCDM ; the split is a robust profile-likelihood parameter shift (up to 6.6σ , 4.8σ in the CMB- and r_d -free pairing, $\gtrsim 3.2\sigma$ by parametric bootstrap), softening to $\sim 1\text{--}2\sigma$ only under the external cosmology-independent anchor combined with the CMB f_{v0} systematic (Sec. V). The early/late dressed- H_0 consistency of Sec. III is thus genuine, but whether one parameter set also describes the combined distance data is unsettled on present evidence, pending the self-consistent sound horizon and cosmology-independent covariance. Notably the same SN-versus-BAO+CMB split recurs across the whole void/backreaction family (Sec. VI), suggesting it is generic to dark-energy-free inhomogeneous

models rather than specific to timescape.

These results sit within known open problems: the timescape CMB fit [12] matches the acoustic-peak structure by adapting an Λ CDM template rather than from first principles; BAO and growth constraints are far less developed than for Λ CDM; and whether backreaction can be dynamically significant is disputed [22, 23].

A. Is the split directional averaging, or model rigidity? A line-of-sight test

Timescape applies one averaged distance–redshift curve to every sightline, yet the local void content is *measured* at low redshift. We tested directly whether injecting it changes the supernova verdict, using the reconstructed 2M++ galaxy density field [43] along the line of sight to each of the 573 Pantheon+ supernovae (460 distinct) inside the reconstruction’s reliable radius ($\lesssim 200 h^{-1}\text{Mpc}$, $z \lesssim 0.067$); redshifts are placed with z_{CMB} , not the peculiar-velocity-corrected z_{HD} , to avoid regressing the data on the same 2M++ field.

Three findings, each a null for the “directional-averaging” hypothesis. First, a generalised-least-squares regression of the Hubble residuals on the per-sightline void fraction, under the full covariance, is consistent with zero once calibrated against a sky-rotation null (-0.9σ); the naive regression error understates the scatter by $\approx 2.7\times$ because it ignores the covariate’s spatial coherence and the covariance’s coherent modes, so an apparent $\sim 2\sigma$ signal is sub-threshold and does not survive. Second, a one-parameter per-sightline extension of the tracker (an expansion-variance coupling to the measured void excess) improves the fit by only $\Delta\chi^2 \approx 0.6$ and leaves $\hat{f}_{v0}$ at 0.85: random rotations of the field help the fit as much on average (rotation-null $p \approx 0.6$). Third, the maximal per-sightline magnitude modulation allowed by the data is $\lesssim 0.05\text{ mag}$, a few percent of the per-supernova error and steeply weighted to $z \lesssim 0.1$, because $\text{Var}(F) \sim L_{\text{void}}/D(z)$ shrinks along longer beams. Measured structure therefore adds no information at Pantheon+ precision: the single-parameter *average* is not the bottleneck, and the low-redshift origin of the supernova preference is a variance/covariance effect rather than a cosmological signal.

Two further checks locate the tension. Externally, the supernova-preferred $f_{v0} \approx 0.85$ exceeds the observed present-day void volume fraction under any structure-based definition (numerical-relativity watershed void statistics bracket $\approx 0.50\text{--}0.62$ [41]), whereas $f_{v0} \approx 0.64$ coincides with both that bracket and timescape’s own Planck fits [12]. And a free, spline-parametrised smooth expansion history fit jointly to supernovae, BAO, and the CMB acoustic scale matches Λ CDM ($\Delta\chi^2 = 10$ for five extra parameters, $p = 0.07$) and sits far below the timescape tracker ($\Delta\chi^2 \approx 67$). A smooth history *can* reconcile the three datasets; the timescape tracker cannot. The SN-versus-BAO+CMB split is thus the rigidity

of the one-parameter averaged history—one f_{v0} forced to serve a low-redshift supernova shape and the BAO+CMB geometry at once—not a failure to resolve directional structure, and not an irreducible supernova–BAO shape disagreement. This is a robustness result: it strengthens, rather than overturns, the recasting interpretation of Sec. VIII.

IX. WHAT A DECISIVE TEST REQUIRES

(i) The cosmology-independent, FLRW-geometry- and peculiar-velocity-independent Pantheon+ covariance of Seifert et al. is now public and we have run it under our harness (Sec. IV D): the supernova preference is scale-dependent—marginally timescape below the statistical-homogeneity scale ($\Delta\text{BIC} = -0.5$), Λ CDM above ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +4.9$ at $z \geq 0.055$)—reproducing the proponents’ redshift-cut trend and their maximum-likelihood void fraction. A fully-marginalised Bayesian evidence, versus our nuisance-profiled approximation, would sharpen the low- z magnitude but not the sign; that is what remains. (ii) A joint re-fit of Pantheon+ and Planck within timescape with the dressed H_0 *free*, and a self-consistent timescape sound-horizon/BAO calibration, so early and late H_0 are genuine independent measurements; the calibrator-anchored late-time half of this test is carried out in Sec. III, leaving the self-consistent sound horizon. (iii) A direct measurement of the radial profile of the apparent H_0 versus scale, to test the predicted expansion variance that the local-excess cross-check assumes.

X. CONCLUSIONS

Within timescape the early- and late-Universe dressed Hubble constants agree to $\lesssim 0.5\sigma$ (versus $\approx 4.9\sigma$ in Λ CDM), and the local excess matches the predicted void-scale variance—but the model recasts rather than reconciles the tension, collapsing both canonical values to $\approx 61\text{ km s}^{-1}\text{ Mpc}^{-1}$, below Planck. Our independent Pantheon+ reanalysis finds Λ CDM favoured under our own full-covariance reductions ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +3.9$ to $+5.1$; exact $\ln B = +1.3$ to $+1.8$), with a timescape preference appearing when the off-diagonal covariance is discarded (stat-only $\ln B = 5.4\text{--}5.9$ for timescape). Run under the proponents’ now-public cosmology-independent covariance, our fit reproduces their published maximum-likelihood values and their scale-dependent result: timescape marginally favoured below the statistical-homogeneity scale ($\Delta\text{BIC} = -0.5$ at $z > 0.01$), Λ CDM above it ($\Delta\text{BIC} = +4.9$ at $z \geq 0.055$). The supernova preference is thus real but a low-redshift, scale-dependent effect, not a robust whole-sample preference. A joint calibration against DESI DR2 BAO and the Planck acoustic scale fits worse than Λ CDM ($\chi^2/\text{dof} = 6.7$ vs 0.89) and prefers a void fraction ($f_{v0} \approx$

0.64) in tension with the supernova value (0.74–0.85) at $4.8\text{--}6.6\sigma$ (profile parameter-shift; $\gtrsim 3.2\sigma$ by parametric bootstrap), softening to $\sim 1\text{--}2\sigma$ only under the external cosmology-independent anchor plus the CMB f_{v0} systematic. The dressed- H_0 numbers *are* reconciled within timescape ($\approx 61\text{ km s}^{-1}\text{ Mpc}^{-1}$); what remains open is whether one parameter set also fits the combined SN+BAO+CMB distances. A uniform test of the wider void/backreaction family (Sec. VI) finds the same SN-vs-BAO+CMB split in every dark-energy-free model and none reaching the local H_0 , with the LTB subclass independently excluded by the kSZ effect. Finally, the tension’s magnitude is calibrator-dependent: the TRGB ladder gives $H_0 \simeq 68\text{--}70$, $\sim 1\text{--}1.5\sigma$ from Planck, so the 5σ tension is largely an artifact of the SH0ES Cepheid calibration. On present public data, eliminating dark energy via inhomogeneity does not resolve the Hubble tension.

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DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

This work uses the public Pantheon+ release [18, 19] (<https://github.com/PantheonPlusSH0ES/DataRelease>). The analysis code (timescape and Λ CDM distance modules, the magnitude $\times$ covariance decomposition, the validation tests, and the figure scripts) is available from the author and will be deposited publicly on publication.

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